In December 2018, as a part of Exercise Bahubali, the Indian Air Force (IAF) deployed tanks and armoured personnel carriers to Leh airport to demonstrate its strategic lift capability to move men and equipment rapidly to border areas.[51] Also that month, *The Indian Express* reported that the IAF was planning to deploy a squadron each of Chinook and Apache helicopters, besides the Russian S-400 missile system and a squadron of the Rafale fighter aircraft, to the contentious eastern border with China. While the induction of Chinook and Apache helicopters is scheduled to be completed by 2020, the S-400 air defence missile system and Rafale fighter jets will be inducted by 2021.[52] The IAF formally received the first American Apache helicopter in March 2019.[53]

The Tibetan factor

In 2016, the Sino–Indian disagreement over Tibet and the border areas was raised and related to Chinese concerns over India's growing alignment with the United States when US Ambassador Richard Verma attended the Tawang festival in Arunachal Pradesh as India's guest of honour. This was the first time a foreign diplomat, let alone the US ambassador, had been extended this invitation, and Chinese reactions followed. While in line with the US view that Arunachal Pradesh belongs to India, China "firmly opposed" the visit, arguing that third parties should not interfere in disputed territories and that the visit would disrupt the "peace and tranquillity" on the border and damage the "hard won peace."[54] In response, the Indian Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) dismissed the significance of the invitation, calling a visit to an Indian province "hardly unusual."